



games, compared with the rich environment of console games, means the games rely more on the game experience rather than the surrounding media. The in-game sound and vision have been enriched almost to a distraction, with game experience almost taking a back seat. According to reports, some players in the mobile gaming industry believe in text-based games whereas others opine that 3D-games will take over the market soon. In fact, content providers think that SMS will be the most successful technology for mobile gaming even in 2005.

Ask Norbert about SMS games and nostalgia takes over, "SMS games were such a novelty: exciting and new to the market, a lot of fun to create... Probably our most famous SMS game was *Dating Annie*. We used a famous Taiwanese movie star, Annie Wu to encourage users. It was a 'character-development' game, in which users, through SMS choices worked to build up their personalities, careers, physical health, etc. The other element of the game involved SMS Essays. Users were invited to express their affection for Annie via SMS messages. The grand prize was a night on the town with Annie. Users responded very strongly to the unusual and unheard of prize."

Jeffrey Kay has been developing software for over twenty years and while he doesn't consider himself to "have significant expertise in the mobile gaming industry"; he nevertheless follows the market closely enough to offer a significant insight. He points out the popularity of SMS games; moreover he sees infotainment as a very viable means to get revenue out of such games. "The show *American Idol*, allows voting using SMS, which provides a revenue stream to the mobile carriers, who charge around 10 cents per message," he adds, "Mobile gaming technology will find areas where revenue is obtainable, most likely through infotainment at first."

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The other half believe, that the technology development will be fast, and advanced two- and three-dimensional games will emerge in the near future. However, very few companies have made definite strategies that they would be pursuing. It seems that the industry is currently lacking persistence and changes the focus whenever a new technology is introduced.

"Both theories are true in way. With the Nokia N-Gage phones, you can get PSone quality graphics on your handheld mobile phone, which makes it a better handheld gaming option than even a Gameboy Advance. But not everyone can really afford a phone such as the N-Gage, and not everyone wants a mobile device solely for the purpose of gaming. That segment may be more than satisfied with the humble arcade games in their cell phones. As far as SMS gaming is concerned, it'll work extremely well if SMS becomes free," explains Gagan.

Info Datamonitor predicts that the year 2005 will witness 200 million people in Western Europe and the United States playing Internet games on their mobile phones

becomes free," explains Gagan.

Entertainment through mobile phones is a nascent business niche that is gaining more attention. SMS games target audiences that are interested in, say, a 5-minute pursuit. The cost for these games is minimal while the market volume is high. The target group of

advanced games is primarily in the age group of 20 to 30-years, who can afford expensive devices. The games sold on such platforms are expensive and the volume of the market is very less.

Fragmented markets and disagreements over standards spawn simple content. Due to limited technology, games such as *Bingo*, cards and quizzes rise up the popularity pole. Games are also expected to expand using the "communicative properties of the phones". Multiplayer and location-specific games are expected to develop. Customers will be willing to pay for playing the games, and most wireless gaming revenue will come from two sources—sponsorship and subscriptions. Priced games will probably be limited to networks that can offer faster service, and therefore higher quality games. Jeffrey expounds, "There will be some revenue obtained through multi-player communities and infotainment as a sub-



scription service. Some games will obtain revenue as a percentage of the fees charged by the carriers for data access. Some games will have to be purchased like software is today."

He points, "Live delivery—via WAP and such—is probably going to take the longest to happen because of the time involved in downloads and the cost to the carriers. Downloadable games will probably focus on multi-player revenue models where subscriptions or percentages of the carrier's data charges can be obtained." The fact is that WAP is an exciting medium; it has a social flavour that appeals to developers such as Norbert, "The technology has allowed us the opportunity of increasing user interaction to the point of creating wireless communities. A WAP game is about far more than just playing, it's also about competition: playing against, or with other users is very exciting."

Talk of technologies, market shares and delivery methods pale in comparison to the passion showed by some of the consumers of this content form. The jubilation

shown by some is virulent. Take Adarsh Kaul for instance: married, working, happy, with a penchant for cell phone gaming that would put a 9-year old kid to shame. His passion certainly rivals one of that age group, "I am an avid fan of *Snake I* and *II*, a highest of 1324 in the first and 2416 in the second! I need to play the game for a solid 52 minutes to get at those scores." His sense of wonder shines bright in his jovial eyes, intent to shatter barriers between fun and religion as he candidly confesses that, "I always hoped that Nokia would host a *Snake* championship, I would win it!"

Dreams have a wonderful property of being shared by all. As Norbert expounds his vision, "We love games, and are always trying to offer better to our users and friends. We anticipate the day when people put down their PS2 joysticks in favour of their phones. For us, the key to success is ultimately found in fantastic games: great graphics, fun and addictive playability. Regardless of the other pieces of the wireless value chain, or the direction that technology may lead, great games will continue to be our goal, and will ultimately be our measure of success." Amen to that. ■

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